Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Moving inner voices, pedal tones, walking bass, passing diminished chords, and spread voicings

LEVEL 81 OF 105 | 10 MODULES | 1,184 EVENTS

Level 81 extends chord melody from static outer-voice control into moving internal architecture. The player must now preserve a recognizable melody while bass lines walk, pedal tones remain fixed, inner voices move chromatically, passing diminished chords connect diatonic harmony, and voicing spacing changes between compact and spread textures.

1. Preserve hierarchy

Melody and bass remain structural. Inner voices may move, disappear, or change register without obscuring the outer frame.

2. Movement must have a job

Walking bass, chromatic inner voices, and diminished connectors must point toward a destination.

3. Voicing is orchestration

Drop-2 and spread voicings change register and texture; they do not replace voice-leading logic.

Level 81 voice hierarchy

```
VOICE 1  melody - must remain traceable
VOICE 2  guide tone / moving inner line
VOICE 3  guide tone / pedal / chord body
VOICE 4  bass - root, inversion, or walk

Reduction order when control fails:
extensions -> fifth -> one guide tone -> full texture
```

Written workload

Module	Events
A	96
B	96
C	128
D	96
E	128
F	96
G	128
H	160
I	192
J	64
TOTAL	1184

Hard-stop architecture

This is Level 81 of the fixed 105-level core curriculum. The core ends at Level 105. Material beyond that belongs in specialization books rather than extending the universal sequence.

Practice rule: if a moving voice cannot be sung separately, it is not yet ready to be embedded inside the chord-melody texture.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Reference: compact, spread, diminished, and reduction vocabulary

VOICE ORDER BEFORE FINGERING

NAME THE FOUR VOICES BEFORE CHOOSING A GRIP

Type	Example	Pitches low->high	Primary use
Drop-2 Cmaj7	x 3 5 4 5 x	C-G-B-E	compact four-note melody/comp texture
Drop-2 G7	x 10 12 10 12 x	G-D-F-B	dominant with top-line third
Spread Cmaj7	8 x 9 9 8 x	C-E-B-G	bass separated from upper voices
Spread G7	3 x 3 4 3 x	G-F-B-D	root + guide tones + fifth
C#dim7	x 4 5 3 5 x	C#-G-Bb-E	passing connector to Dm7
G#dim7	x 11 12 10 12 x	G#-D-F-B	leading diminished into A minor

Reduction ladder

```
FULL: melody + upper guide + lower guide + bass
REDUCE 1: melody + one guide + bass
REDUCE 2: melody + bass
REDUCE 3: melody only
RESTORE: bass -> guide tone -> optional color
```

The purpose of reduction is not to make the music easier permanently. It identifies which voice is causing the breakdown while the form continues.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module A - moving inner voices, studies 1-3

3 STUDIES | 48 EVENTS

OUTER FRAME STAYS RECOGNIZABLE WHILE ONE INNER VOICE MOVES

Cmaj7 - inner line B-C-B-A

```
Degrees: 7-R-7-6
Bass:    C bass
Pulse:   four quarter-note inner movements
```

hold E or G as lower inner voice

Passes: sing inner line -> melody + inner -> bass + inner -> full texture -> remove the inner voice and confirm the harmony still makes sense.

Am7 - inner line G-G#-A-G

```
Degrees: b7-7-R-b7
Bass:    A bass
Pulse:   four quarter-note inner movements
```

G# is a chromatic passing voice; do not rename Am

Passes: sing inner line -> melody + inner -> bass + inner -> full texture -> remove the inner voice and confirm the harmony still makes sense.

Dm7 - inner line C-C#-D-C

```
Degrees: b7-7-R-b7
Bass:    D bass
Pulse:   four quarter-note inner movements
```

chromatic upper neighbor resolves into D

Passes: sing inner line -> melody + inner -> bass + inner -> full texture -> remove the inner voice and confirm the harmony still makes sense.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module A - moving inner voices, studies 4-6

3 STUDIES | 48 EVENTS

OUTER FRAME STAYS RECOGNIZABLE WHILE ONE INNER VOICE MOVES

G7 - inner line F-F#-G-F

```
Degrees: b7-7-R-b7
Bass:    G bass
Pulse:   four quarter-note inner movements
```

F# is a passing tone, not a new chord quality

Passes: sing inner line -> melody + inner -> bass + inner -> full texture -> remove the inner voice and confirm the harmony still makes sense.

Cmaj7 -> A7 - inner line B-Bb-A-G#

```
Degrees: 7-b7-6-#5
Bass:    C -> A bass
Pulse:   four quarter-note inner movements
```

hear the inner descent while melody E stays fixed

Passes: sing inner line -> melody + inner -> bass + inner -> full texture -> remove the inner voice and confirm the harmony still makes sense.

Dm7 -> G7 - inner line C-B-Bb-B

```
Degrees: b7-3-b3-3
Bass:    D -> G bass
Pulse:   four quarter-note inner movements
```

target B as the G7 third

Passes: sing inner line -> melody + inner -> bass + inner -> full texture -> remove the inner voice and confirm the harmony still makes sense.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module B - pedal-tone independence, studies 1-3

3 STUDIES | 48 EVENTS

ONE PITCH REMAINS FIXED WHILE ITS FUNCTION CHANGES

High E pedal

```
Harmony: Cmaj7 | Am7 | Fmaj7 | E7
Pedal:   E-E-E-E
Function:E = 3,5,7,root
```

Hold or re-articulate the pedal at the same dynamic while the remaining voices establish the new harmony. Do not let the pedal become louder merely because it is stationary.

High G pedal

```
Harmony: Cmaj7 | Em7 | Am7 | G7
Pedal:   G-G-G-G
Function:G = 5,b3,b7,root
```

Hold or re-articulate the pedal at the same dynamic while the remaining voices establish the new harmony. Do not let the pedal become louder merely because it is stationary.

High C pedal

```
Harmony: Am7 | Fmaj7 | Dm7 | G7
Pedal:   C-C-C-C
Function:C = b3,5,b7,11
```

Hold or re-articulate the pedal at the same dynamic while the remaining voices establish the new harmony. Do not let the pedal become louder merely because it is stationary.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module B - pedal-tone independence, studies 4-6

3 STUDIES | 48 EVENTS

ONE PITCH REMAINS FIXED WHILE ITS FUNCTION CHANGES

Bass C pedal

```
Harmony: Cmaj7 | Dm7/C | G7/C | Cmaj7
Pedal:   C-C-C-C
Function:upper harmony changes above fixed tonic
```

Hold or re-articulate the pedal at the same dynamic while the remaining voices establish the new harmony. Do not let the pedal become louder merely because it is stationary.

Bass A pedal

```
Harmony: Am7 | D/A | F/A | E7/A
Pedal:   A-A-A-A
Function:hear 1,5,3,11 over changing upper structure
```

Hold or re-articulate the pedal at the same dynamic while the remaining voices establish the new harmony. Do not let the pedal become louder merely because it is stationary.

Inner E pedal

```
Harmony: Cmaj7 | Am7 | Fmaj7 | E7
Pedal:   E-E-E-E
Function:retain one middle voice while outer voices move
```

Hold or re-articulate the pedal at the same dynamic while the remaining voices establish the new harmony. Do not let the pedal become louder merely because it is stationary.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module C - walking bass construction, studies 1-4

4 STUDIES | 64 EVENTS

BASS MOTION MUST ARRIVE ON THE NEXT HARMONIC LANDMARK

C major descending

```
Bass: C-B-A-G
Harmony: Cmaj7 -> Cmaj7/B -> Am7 -> G7
```

Play bass alone, then bass + top melody, then add guide tones only on structural beats.

A minor descending

```
Bass: A-G-F-E
Harmony: Am7 -> G7 -> Fmaj7 -> E7
```

Play bass alone, then bass + top melody, then add guide tones only on structural beats.

C major ascending

```
Bass: C-D-E-F
Harmony: Cmaj7 -> Dm7 -> Em7 -> Fmaj7
```

Play bass alone, then bass + top melody, then add guide tones only on structural beats.

A minor ascending

```
Bass: A-B-C-D
Harmony: Am7 -> Bm7b5 -> Cmaj7 -> Dm7
```

Play bass alone, then bass + top melody, then add guide tones only on structural beats.

Walking-bass rule: approach notes may be diatonic or chromatic, but beat 1 of the destination chord must sound intentional and rhythmically secure.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module C - walking bass construction, studies 5-8

4 STUDIES | 64 EVENTS

BASS MOTION MUST ARRIVE ON THE NEXT HARMONIC LANDMARK

Approach G7

```
Bass: D-E-F-F# -> G
Harmony: Dm7 over D-E-F-F#, then G7
```

Play bass alone, then bass + top melody, then add guide tones only on structural beats.

Approach Cmaj7

```
Bass: G-F-E-D-Db -> C
Harmony: G7 descent with chromatic Db approach
```

Play bass alone, then bass + top melody, then add guide tones only on structural beats.

Approach Am7

```
Bass: E-F-F#-G-G# -> A
Harmony: E7 / passing diminished color into Am
```

Play bass alone, then bass + top melody, then add guide tones only on structural beats.

Turnaround walk

```
Bass: C-B-Bb-A-Ab-G
Harmony: Cmaj7 -> C7/Bb -> A7 -> Ab7 -> G7 color route
```

Play bass alone, then bass + top melody, then add guide tones only on structural beats.

Walking-bass rule: approach notes may be diatonic or chromatic, but beat 1 of the destination chord must sound intentional and rhythmically secure.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module D - passing diminished chords

8 CELLS | 96 EVENTS

PASSING DIMINISHED CHORDS CONNECT; THEY DO NOT BECOME NEW TONAL CENTERS

Route	Source	Dim connector	Destination	Top-line idea
Cmaj7 -> C#dim7 -> Dm7	x 3 5 4 5 x	x 4 5 3 5 x	x 5 7 5 6 x	G
Dm7 -> D#dim7 -> Em7	x 5 7 5 6 x	x 6 7 5 7 x	x 7 9 7 8 x	A
Fmaj7 -> F#dim7 -> G7	x 8 10 9 10 x	x 9 10 8 10 x	x 10 12 10 12 x	C
G7 -> G#dim7 -> Am7	x 10 12 10 12 x	x 11 12 10 12 x	x 12 14 12 13 x	D/E
Am7 -> A#dim7 -> Bm7b5	x 12 14 12 13 x	x 13 14 12 14 x	x 14 15 14 15 x	E/F
Cmaj7 -> Edim7 -> Dm7/F	x 3 5 4 5 x	x x 2 3 2 3	x x 3 2 3 1	G/F
E7 -> G#dim7 -> Am	0 2 0 1 0 0	4 x 3 4 3 x	5 7 7 5 5 5	B

Functional test

Remove the diminished chord. If the source-to-destination motion is still clear, reinsert the diminished voicing as a one-beat or half-beat connector. If it sounds like a new tonic, shorten it or simplify the voicing.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module E - drop-2 voicing control

8 VOICINGS | 128 EVENTS

COMPACT FOUR-NOTE VOICINGS: HEAR PITCH ORDER, NOT JUST SHAPE

Chord	Voicing	Pitches	Voice order
Cmaj7	x 3 5 4 5 x	C-G-B-E	R-5-7-3
Cm7	x 3 5 3 4 x	C-G-Bb-Eb	R-5-b7-b3
C7	x 3 5 3 5 x	C-G-Bb-E	R-5-b7-3
Cm7b5	x 3 4 3 4 x	C-Gb-Bb-Eb	R-b5-b7-b3
Dm7	x 5 7 5 6 x	D-A-C-F	R-5-b7-b3
G7	x 10 12 10 12 x	G-D-F-B	R-5-b7-3
Am7	x 12 14 12 13 x	A-E-G-C	R-5-b7-b3

Cycle drill

For each shape: blocked chord x4 -> low-to-high arpeggio -> top-to-low arpeggio -> melody-emphasis pass. Then connect Cmaj7-Am7-Dm7-G7 using the nearest available top note rather than forcing one fixed grip.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module F - drop-3 / spread-voicing control

6 VOICINGS | 96 EVENTS

SPREAD THE BASS AWAY FROM THE CHORD BODY WITHOUT LOSING INNER-VOICE LOGIC

Chord	Voicing	Pitches low->high	Voice order
Cmaj7	8 x 9 9 8 x	C-E-B-G	R-3-7-5
Cm7	8 x 8 8 8 x	C-Eb-Bb-G	R-b3-b7-5
C7	8 x 8 9 8 x	C-Bb-E-G	R-b7-3-5
Dm7	10 x 10 10 10 x	D-F-C-A	R-b3-b7-5
G7	3 x 3 4 3 x	G-F-B-D	R-b7-3-5

Bass separation drill

Play bass alone on beat 1, upper three voices on beat 2, bass on beat 3, upper voices on beat 4. Then compress the same harmony into the Level-80 compact texture.

Comfort rule

A spread voicing is optional orchestration. If the stretch destabilizes melody, intonation, or pulse, omit the fifth or move the upper structure to a nearer inversion.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module G - independent-voice integration, studies 1-4

4 STUDIES | 64 EVENTS

COMBINE ONLY TWO MOVING SYSTEMS AT FIRST; ADD THE THIRD AFTER THEY ARE STABLE

Pedal melody + walking bass

```
Voices:  Melody G held; bass C-B-A-G
Harmony: Cmaj7 -> Cmaj7/B -> Am7 -> G7
```

Build: outer voices -> add one inner voice -> full texture -> reduction test.

Pedal bass + moving top

```
Voices:  C bass; melody E-F-G-E
Harmony: Cmaj7 -> Dm7/C -> G7/C -> Cmaj7
```

Build: outer voices -> add one inner voice -> full texture -> reduction test.

Walking bass + guide dyad

```
Voices:  Bass D-E-F-F# -> G
Harmony: guide voices C->B and F->F over Dm7->G7
```

Build: outer voices -> add one inner voice -> full texture -> reduction test.

Passing diminished + melody

```
Voices:  Cmaj7 -> C#dim7 -> Dm7
Harmony: hold G on top, then resolve to F or A
```

Build: outer voices -> add one inner voice -> full texture -> reduction test.

Integration limit: if more than one voice becomes rhythmically uncertain, reduce immediately. Complexity is earned one independent layer at a time.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module G - independent-voice integration, studies 5-8

4 STUDIES | 64 EVENTS

COMBINE ONLY TWO MOVING SYSTEMS AT FIRST; ADD THE THIRD AFTER THEY ARE STABLE

Drop-2 comp + melody answer

```
Voices:  Cmaj7 / Am7 / Dm7 / G7
Harmony: one blocked voicing, then two-note top-line answer
```

Build: outer voices -> add one inner voice -> full texture -> reduction test.

Spread voicing + bass fill

```
Voices:  Cmaj7 -> Am7
Harmony: hold upper three notes; bass walks C-B-A
```

Build: outer voices -> add one inner voice -> full texture -> reduction test.

Contrary outer voices

```
Voices:  Bass C-D-E-F; melody G-F-E-D
Harmony: inner thirds/sevenths only on beats 1 and 3
```

Build: outer voices -> add one inner voice -> full texture -> reduction test.

Reduction ladder

```
Voices:  full voicing -> drop inner -> bass+melody -> melody
Harmony: restore voices in reverse order
```

Build: outer voices -> add one inner voice -> full texture -> reduction test.

Integration limit: if more than one voice becomes rhythmically uncertain, reduce immediately. Complexity is earned one independent layer at a time.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module H - arrangement 1 - c major walking ballad

8 BARS | 40 EVENTS

MELODY AND BASS FIRST; GUIDE TONES SECOND; FULL VOICING LAST

Arrangement 1 - C major walking ballad

```
| Cmaj7 | Cmaj7/B | Am7 | G7 |

| Fmaj7 | F#dim7 | G7 | Cmaj7 |

Melody: E G | G E | C E | B D | A C | C A | B D | E C

Bass:   C B | A G | F F# | G C
```

Five rehearsal passes

1. Melody only. 2. Bass only. 3. Melody + bass. 4. Add guide tones on beats 1 and 3. 5. Full arrangement with selected drop-2 or spread voicings.

Reduction test

Remove all inner voices. The eight-bar form must still be recognizable from bass and melody. Restore only the voices that improve harmonic clarity.

Performance target: no pause at chord changes, no hidden melody, and no passing chord longer than its connecting function requires.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module H - arrangement 2 - a minor pedal and cadence

8 BARS | 40 EVENTS

MELODY AND BASS FIRST; GUIDE TONES SECOND; FULL VOICING LAST

Arrangement 2 - A minor pedal and cadence

```
| Am7 | G7 | Fmaj7 | E7 |

| Am7 | Dm7 | E7 | AmMaj7 |

Melody: E E | E D | E C | B G# | C E | F A | G# B | G# A

Bass:   A G | F E | A D | E A
```

Five rehearsal passes

1. Melody only. 2. Bass only. 3. Melody + bass. 4. Add guide tones on beats 1 and 3. 5. Full arrangement with selected drop-2 or spread voicings.

Reduction test

Remove all inner voices. The eight-bar form must still be recognizable from bass and melody. Restore only the voices that improve harmonic clarity.

Performance target: no pause at chord changes, no hidden melody, and no passing chord longer than its connecting function requires.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module H - arrangement 3 - ii-v-i with passing diminished

8 BARS | 40 EVENTS

MELODY AND BASS FIRST; GUIDE TONES SECOND; FULL VOICING LAST

Arrangement 3 - ii-V-I with passing diminished

```
| Dm7 | D#dim7 | Em7 | A7 |

| Dm7 | G7 | Cmaj7 | C#dim7 |

Melody: F A | F# A | G B | C# E | F A | B D | E G | G E

Bass:   D D# | E A | D G | C C#
```

Five rehearsal passes

1. Melody only. 2. Bass only. 3. Melody + bass. 4. Add guide tones on beats 1 and 3. 5. Full arrangement with selected drop-2 or spread voicings.

Reduction test

Remove all inner voices. The eight-bar form must still be recognizable from bass and melody. Restore only the voices that improve harmonic clarity.

Performance target: no pause at chord changes, no hidden melody, and no passing chord longer than its connecting function requires.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module H - arrangement 4 - register-spread study

8 BARS | 40 EVENTS

MELODY AND BASS FIRST; GUIDE TONES SECOND; FULL VOICING LAST

Arrangement 4 - register-spread study

```
| Cmaj7 | Am7 | Dm7 | G7 |

| Em7 | A7 | Dm7 | G7 |

Texture: drop-2 -> spread -> drop-2 -> spread, then reverse

Melody targets: E | C | F | B | G | C# | A | F
```

Five rehearsal passes

1. Melody only. 2. Bass only. 3. Melody + bass. 4. Add guide tones on beats 1 and 3. 5. Full arrangement with selected drop-2 or spread voicings.

Reduction test

Remove all inner voices. The eight-bar form must still be recognizable from bass and melody. Restore only the voices that improve harmonic clarity.

Performance target: no pause at chord changes, no hidden melody, and no passing chord longer than its connecting function requires.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module I - twenty-four-bar independent-voice capstone, bars 1-12

12 BARS | 96 EVENTS

OUTER VOICES DEFINE THE FORM; INNER VOICES DEFINE THE COLOR

Bar	Chord	Bass	Melody	Job
1	Cmaj7	C	E	statement
2	Cmaj7/B	B	G	walking descent
3	Am7	A	C	answer
4	G7	G	B	cadence
5	Fmaj7	F	A	expansion
6	F#dim7	F#	A	passing diminished
7	G7	G	B	dominant
8	Cmaj7	C	E	tonic
9	Am7	A	E	pedal melody begins
10	G7	G	E	E remains top color
11	Fmaj7	F	E	major seventh top

Passes: 1) bass + melody only; 2) add guide tones; 3) add passing diminished / walking bass where printed; 4) choose compact or spread voicings by register; 5) record one uninterrupted take.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module I - twenty-four-bar independent-voice capstone, bars 13-24

12 BARS | 96 EVENTS

OUTER VOICES DEFINE THE FORM; INNER VOICES DEFINE THE COLOR

Bar	Chord	Bass	Melody	Job
13	Am7	A	C	minor tonic
14	Dm7	D	F	predominant
15	E7	E	G#	leading tone
16	AmMaj7	A	G#	minor-major tonic
17	Dm7	D	F	ii in C
18	D#dim7	D#	F#	passing diminished
19	Em7	E	G	arrival
20	A7	A	C#	secondary dominant
21	Dm7	D	A	release
22	G7	G	B	final dominant
23	Cmaj7	C	G	broad tonic

Passes: 1) bass + melody only; 2) add guide tones; 3) add passing diminished / walking bass where printed; 4) choose compact or spread voicings by register; 5) record one uninterrupted take.

Guitar Exercises - Section XI, Level 81

Module J - recovery, mastery gate, and fixed roadmap

LEVEL 81 COMPLETE | 24 LEVELS REMAIN

THE CORE CURRICULUM ENDS AT LEVEL 105 - NO LEVEL 106 IN THE UNIVERSAL SEQUENCE

Recovery cards

Melody disappears: remove one inner voice; restore bass + melody first.

Pedal tone breaks: freeze upper/lower voices; rebuild harmony around the pedal.

Walking bass arrives late: reduce chord to shell; make bass land on beat 1.

Passing diminished sounds random: play source and destination only; reinsert diminished as one-beat connector.

Drop-2 grip is noisy: arpeggiate four voices; restore blocked attack after clean scan.

Spread voicing causes stretch: omit fifth or extension; preserve melody, bass, and guide tone.

Voice crossing confuses melody: move inner voice down an octave; keep top line highest.

Form lost: roots + melody targets only; re-enter full texture at cadence.

Mastery gate

- [ ] Sing moving inner voices independently
- [ ] Hold six pedal-tone studies without drift
- [ ] Perform eight walking-bass routes
- [ ] Use all eight diminished connectors functionally
- [ ] Play eight drop-2 voicings cleanly
- [ ] Play six spread voicings without strain
- [ ] Perform eight integration studies
- [ ] Complete four eight-bar arrangements
- [ ] Perform 24-bar capstone twice

Capstone score - 0 to 2 each

- [ ] Melody clarity
- [ ] Bass timing
- [ ] Inner-voice accuracy
- [ ] Pedal-tone stability
- [ ] Diminished-chord function
- [ ] Voicing cleanliness
- [ ] Pulse / form
- [ ] Recovery

Pass at 14/16 or better on two separate days, with no zero in melody clarity, bass timing, pulse/form, or recovery.

Next level

Level 82 will develop walking-bass chord melody, stronger bass-to-chord independence, chromatic approach bass lines, bass substitutions, and longer solo-guitar arrangements in which the bass line carries its own phrase shape.

Roadmap lock: Levels 81-84 complete Section XI; the universal curriculum continues only through Level 105, then hard stops.